The Universal Language

By David Ives

DAWN: H-h-h-h-hello...? [She steps in quietly.] Hello? Is anyb-b-b-ody here? {No response. She sees the blackboard, reads.] "He. She. It. Arf." [She notices the numbers around the walls, and reads.] "Wen - yu - fre - fal- fynd - iff - heven - waitz." (Noticing the empty chairs, she practices her greeting, as if there were people sitting in them.] Hello, my name is Dawn. It's very nice to meet you. How do you do, my name is Dawn. A pleasure to meet you. Hello. My name is Dawn. [The door at left opens and DON appears.]

DON: Velcro! ["Welcome!"] ,

DAWN: Excuse me?

DON: Velcro! Belljar, Froyling! Harvardyu? ["Welcome. Good day, Miss. How are you?"]

DAWN: H-h-h-how do you d-d-d-do, my n-n-name is [Breaks off) I'm sorry. [She turns to go.)

DON: Oop, oop, oop! Varta, Froyling! Varta! Varta! ["No, no, no! Wait, Miss! Wait!"]

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *There are over 5000 languages on earth*
ACTRESS: *5000 different ways to say "hello, goodbye, I love you."*
ACTOR: *If you listen to a two year old develop language, they say the noun and the verb and always in the present tense. A child experiences life in the now. That's all they need to convey the message. We like to flower it up with adjectives and talk about the future and the past but the gist remains the same.*
ACTRESS: *So now if we boil down the spoken word to simple concepts like a child does, then creating a new universal language that has a small amount of words may be the answer. English may be the starting point for this language but I believe there is one more answer to this question.*
ACTOR: *We should all learn Unamunda . . .*
TOGETHER: *The Universal Language by David Ives.*

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DAWN: I'm v-very sorry to b-b-bother you.

DON: Mock - klahtoo boddam nikto! Ventrica! Ventrica, ventrica Police! ["But - you're not bothering me at all! Enter. Please."]

DAWN: Really - I think I have the wrong place.

DON: Da rrrroongplatz? Oop da-doll! Du doppa da rektplatz! Dameetcha playzeer. Comintern. Police. Plop da chah. ["The wrong place? Not at all! You have the right place. Pleased to meet you. Come in. Please. Have a seat."]

DAWN: Well. J-just for a second.

DON: [Cleaning up papers on the floor.] Squeegie la mezza. ["Excuse the mess"] [He points to the chair.) Zitz?

DAWN: No thank you. [She sits)

DON: Argo. ["So."] Belljar, Froyling. Harvardyu?

DAWN: "Belljar?"

DON: Belljar. Bell. Jar. Belljar!

DAWN: Is that "good day"-?

DON: Ding! ["Yes."] "Bell jar" arf"good day." Epp ["And - "] Harvardyu?

DAWN: Harvard University?

DON: Oop! ["No."] Harvardyu?

DAWN: Howard Hughes?

DON: Oop! Harvardyu?

DAWN: Oh! "How are you."

DON: Bleeny, bleeny! Bonanza bleeny! ["Good, good, very good."]

DAWN: Is this The School of Unamunda?

DON: Hets arf dada Unamunda Kaka-daymee. ["This is the School of Unamunda."] Epp vot kennedy doopferyu? ["And what can I do for you?"]

DAWN: Do you speak English?

DON: "English"...?

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DAWN: English.

DON: Ah! Johndeese!

DAWN: Yes. Johndeese.

DON: Johndeese. Squeegie, squeegie. Alaska, iago parladoop johndeese. ["Sorry. Unfortunately, I don't speak English."]

DAWN: No johndeese at all?

DON: One, two, three worlds. "Khello. Goombye. Rice Krispies. Chevrolet." Et cinema, et cinema. Mock - votsdy beesnest, bella Froyling? ["But - what brings you here?"]

DAWN: Well I wanted to be the first. Or among the first. To learn this universal language.

DON: Du arf entra di feersta di feersten. Corngranulations. Ya kooch di anda. [He kisses her hand.] Epp! Voila-dimir da zamplification forum. [produces an application form.]

DAWN: Well I'm not sure I'm ready to apply just yet...

DON: Dy klink, pink dama? ["Your name?"]

DAWN: "Dy klink..."?

DON: Votsdy klink? Vee klinks du?

DAWN: Urn. No nabisco. [As if to say, I don't understand.]

DON: No nabisco. Klinks duMary, klinks duJane, orf Betsy, orf Barbara, orf Tina...? Tessie? Fred?

DAWN: Oh. My name!

DON: Attackly! Mi klink. Echo mi. "Mi klink..."

DAWN: Mi klink.

DON: "Arf." Parla.

DAWN: Mi klink arfDawn di-di-di-Vito.

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DON: Dawn di-di-di-Vito! Vot'n harmonika klink doppa du! ["What a melodious name you have!"]

DAWN: Actually, just one d-d- "d."

DON: Ah. Dawn di Vito. Squeegie.

DAWN: I have a s-s-slight s-s

DON: Stutter.

DAWN: Yes.

DON: Tonguestoppard. Problaymen mit da hoover.

DAWN: Da hoover?

DON: ["Mouth."] Da hoover. ["Face, nose, lips."] Da veasle, da nozzle, da volvos, da hoover. Et cinema, et cinema. Mock! Hets arf blizzardo. Hets arf molto blizzardo! ["This is very strange,"]

DAWN: Something's wrong?

DON: Dusa klinks "Dawn." !ago klink "Don." Badabba? ["Understand?"]

DAWN: Urn. No.

DON: Dawn-Don. Don-Dawn.

DAWN: I'm Dawn and you're Don.

DON: Ding. Arf blizzardo, oop?

DAWN: Arfblizzardo, yes.

DON: Neekolas importantay. [Back to the application form.) Argo. Da bin formations. Edge?

DAWN: Twenty-eight.

DON: "Vont-wait." Slacks?

DAWN: Female.

DON: "Vittamin."

DAWN: How do you say "male"?

DON: "Aspirin." Oxipation?

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DAWN: I'm a word processor.

DON: "Verboblender..."

DAWN: Is Unamunda very hard to learn?

DON: Eedgy. Egsovereedgy. [He takes a book off a chair.] Da bop.

DAWN: Da bop?

DON: Da bop.

DAWN: Oh. Book.

DON: Da bop. ["The room"] Da rhoomba. ["The walls"] Da valtz. ["The door"] Isadora. ["The chair"] Da chah. ["Two chairs"] Da chah-chah.

DON & DAWN: ["Three chairs"] Da chah-chah-chah!

DON: Braga! Sonia braga! lago trattoria Shakespeare enda Unamunda.

DAWN: You're translating Shakespeare ito Unamunda?

DON: Forsoot! - Nintendo. ["Listen."] "Ah Romeo, Romeo, bilko arfst du Romeo?" [pointing to a rose on the desk.] "Na rosa pollyanna klink voop sent so pink!" Balloontiful, eh?

DAWN: Yes. Bonzo.

DON: Bonanza.

DAWN: Bonanza.

DON: "Mock visp! Vot loomen trip yondra fenstra sheint? Arf den oyster! Epp Juliet arf sonnnng!" Video, Froyling, Unamunda arf da linkwa supreemka di amamor!

DAWN: You know it's strange how much I understand. SO "linkwa" is "language"?

DON: Perzacto. Wen linkwa. [He holds up one finger.] Yew - [Two fingers.]

DAWN: Two

DON: Linkages. Free - [Three fingers.]

DAWN: Three

DON: Linguini.

DAWN: I see. And "is" is - ?

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DON: Arf.

DAWN: "Was" is - ?

DON: Wharf.

DAWN: "Had been" - ?

DON: Long wharf.

DAWN: And "will be" - ?

DON: Barf. Arf, wharf, barf. Pasta, prison, furniture dances. ["Past, present, future tenses."]

DAWN: Well, Mr.

DON: Finninneganegan. [- like "Finnegan," slurred. "Finninn-againagain.]

DAWN: What kind of name is that?

DON: Fininnish.

DAWN: Mr. F-F-F-F

DON: Police! Klink mi "Don."

DAWN: I'd love to learn Unamunda. I mean, if it isn't too expensive.

DON: {perfect English.] Five hundred dollars.

DAWN: Five hundred dollars?

DON: Cash.

DAWN: Five hundred dollars is a lot of money.

DON: Kalamari, Froyling! Kalamari! Da payola arf oopsissima importantay! ["Be calm, be calm! The money isn't important!"]

DAWN: I don't have much money.

DON: Oop doppa bonanza geld. Ya badabba. ["You don't have much money. I understand."]

DAWN: And the thing is, I do have this s-s-slight s-s-s

DON: Stutter. Ya badabba. Joe diMaggio. Mock no seperanto, Froyling! ["That's too bad. But don't despair!"] Porky mit Unamunda - oop tonguestoppard.

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DAWN: I wouldn't stutter?

DON: Oop.

DAWN: At all?

DON: Absaloopdiloop.

DAWN: The thing is, just because I'm quiet doesn't mean I have nothing to say. I believe that language is the opposite of loneliness. And if everybody in the world spoke the same language, who would ever be lonely? I just think English isn't my language. Since it only m-makes p people laugh at me. And makes me...

DON: Lornly.

DAWN: Ding. Very lornly. So will you teach me Unamunda? I do have a little money saved up.

DON: Donutsayev deedeena vanya. ["Don't say I didn't warn you."] Dollripe-chus. Boggle da zitzbells. Arf raddly? ["All right. Buckle your seatbelts. Are you ready?"]

DAWN: Yes. I'm raddly.

DON: Raza la tabooli. Kontsentreeren. Lax da hoover, lax da hoover. Epp echo mi. ["Clear your mind. Concentrate. Relax your mouth, relax your mouth. And repeat after me."] (picks up a pointer.) Schtick.

DAWN: Schtick. /DON puts the pointer down, and begins the pronouns.)

DON: {pointing to himself] Ya.

DAWN: Ya.

DON: (points to her.) Du.

DAWN: Du.

DON: (points to "he" on the blackboard.) En.

DAWN: En.

DON: [points to "SHE" on the blackboard.] Dee.

DAWN: Dee.

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DON: [points to "IT".] Da.

DAWN: Da.

DON: ["WE."] Wop.

DAWN: Wop.

DON: ["YOU."] Doobly.

DAWN: Doobly.

DON: ["THEY"] Day.

DAWN: Day.

DON: Du badabba?

DAWN: Ya badabba duo

DON: Testicle. ["Test. "]

DAWN: Al dente? ["Already?"]

DON: Shmal testicle. Epp - alIa togandhi. ["Small test. And - all together."]

DAWN: [As he points to "I, YOU, WE, HE, YOU, THEY'} Ya du wop en doobly day.

DON & DAWN: [DON points to her, then "IT. ') Doo da! Doo da!

DAWN: [Sings "Camptown ladies sing this song.'} Ya du wop en doobly day

DON & DAWN: [Sing together} Arf da doo-dah day!

DON: Bleeny, bleeny bonanza bleeny!

DAWN: Reedly-dee?

DON: Indeedly-dee. [Dawn raises her hand.] Quisling?

DAWN: How do you say "how-do-you-say"?

DON: Howardjohnson.

DAWN: Howardjohnson "to have"?

DON: Doppa.

DAWN: SO - {Indicating "he, you, she') En doppa, du doppa, dee doppa.

DON: Ding!

DAWN: [Faster.] En doppa, du doppa, dee doppa.

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DON: Ding!

DAWN: [Faster still, swinging it.] En doppa, du doppa, dee doppa. ["They"] Day.

DON: Bleeny con cavyar! Scoop da gwan?

DAWN: Ya scoop if du do.

DON: Dopple scoop! [points left.] Eedon.

DAWN: Eedon.

DON: [pointing right.] Ged.

DAWN: Ged.

DON: [pointing up.] Enro.

DAWN: Enro.

DON: [pointing down.] Rok.

DAWN: Rok.

DON: [Right.] Ged.

DAWN: Ged.

DON: [Up.] Enro.

DAWN: Enro.

DON: [Left.] EeDon.

DAWN: EeDon.

DON: [Down.] Rok.

DAWN: Rok.

DON: Argo...

DON & DAWN: Ged eedon rok enro, ged eedon rok enro! ["Get it on, rock and roll, get it on, rock and roll!]

DAWN: This is fun!

DON: Dinksdu diss is flan? ["You think this is fun?"]

DAWN: Flantastico!

DON: Ives-ing onda kick. [Holds out hand.] Di anda.

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DAWN: Di anda.

DON: [palm.] Da palma.

DAWN: Da palma.

DON: [Index finger.] Da vinci.

DAWN: Da vinci.

DON: [Middle finger.] Di niro.

DAWN: Di niro.

DON: [Thumb.] Da bamba.

DAWN: Da bamba

DON: [Leg.] Da jamba.

DAWN: Da jamba.

DON & DAWN: [Doing a two-step.] Da jambo-ree!

DON: Zoopa! Zoopa mit noodel!

DAWN: Minestrone, minestrone! ["Wait a second!"] Howardjohnson "little"?

DON: Diddly.

DAWN: Howardjohnson "big"?

DON: Da-wow.

DAWN: Argo...

DON: Doppa du a diddly anda? ["Do you have a small hand?"]

DAWN: Yago doppa diddly anda, dusa doopa doppa diddlyanda. ["I have a small hand, you don't have a small hand."]

DON: Scoopa du da diddly bop? ["Do you want a little book?"]

DAWN: Oop scoopa diddly bop, iago scoopa bop da-wow! ["I don't want a little book, I want a big book."]

DON & DAWN: Oop scoopa diddly bop, iago scoopa bop da-wow, da-wow, da-wow!

DON: A-plotz, Froyling. A-plotz! ["A-plus."] Wharf das gold for yu? ["Was that good for you?"]

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DAWN: Gold formeeka? Das wharf gland! Wharf das gold for yu?

DON: Das wharf da skool da fortnox!

DAWN: GOOMBYE ENGLISH, BELLJAR UNAMUNDA! Oh, sor denly ya sensa socha frill da joy! ["Suddenly I feel such a thrill of joy!"]

DON: Dawn...

DAWN: My slaveyard! [She rushes to embrace him, but he slips aside.]

DON: Police! Froyling di Vito!

DAWN: Du gabriel mi a balloontiful grift, Don. A linkwa. Epp frontier ta deepternity, yago parlo osolomiento Unamunda! ["You gave me a beautiful gift, Don. A language. And from here to eternity I'm going to speak only Unamunda!"] [Suddenly remembering.] Mock... da payola!

DON: Da payola.

DAWN: Da geld. Fordham letsin. ["The money for the lesson."] [Holding out money.] Dots allada geld ya doppda mit mi. Cheer. ["That's all the money I have with me. Here."] Cheer! Melgibson da rest end a morgen. ["I'll give you the rest tomorrow."]

DON: I can't take your money, Dawn.

DAWN: Squeegie...?

DON: I'm sorry, but I... I c-c-can't take your money.

DAWN: Du parla johncleese?

DON: Actually, yes, I do speak a little johncleese.

DAWN: Mock du parlit parfoom!

DON: I've been practicing a lot. Anyway, 1-1-1-1 don't think I mentioned that the first lesson is free.

DAWN: Votsda mattress? Cheer! Etsyuris! ["What's the matter? Here! It's yours!"]

DON: I can't take it.

DAWN: Porky?

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DON: Because it's a fraud.

DAWN: Squeegie?

DON: Unamunda. It's a fraud. It's a con game. A swindle. A parla trick.

DAWN: No crayola. ["I don't believe you."]

DON: Believe it, Dawn! I should know - I invented it! Granted, it's not a very good con, since you're the only person who's ever knocked at that door, and I'm obviously not a very good con man, since I'm refusing to accept your very attractive and generous money, but I can't stand the thought of you walking out there saying "velcro belljar harvardyu" and having people laugh at you. I swear, Dawn, I swear, I didn't want to hurt you. How could I? How could anybody? Your beautiful heart... It shines out of you like a beacon. And then there's me. A total fraud. I wish I could lie in any language and say it wasn't so, but... I'm sorry, Dawn. I'm so, so... sorry.

DAWN: Unamunda arf da linkwa looniversahl!

DON: But you and I are the only peepholes in da voooid who speak it!

DAWN: Dolby udders! Dolby udders! ["There'll be others!"]

DON: Who? What others?

DAWN: Don, if you and I can speak this linkwa supreemka, anybody can. Everybody will! This isn't just any language. This isn't just any room! This is the Garden of Eden. And you and I are finding names for a whole new world. I was so...

DON: Happy. I know. So was I.

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AWARD HISTORY

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